

Jade Zhao

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Summary

Informatics student at Indiana University researching digital humans, AI-driven virtual personas, and the intersection of artificial intelligence, human-computer interaction, and business strategy. Experience spans applied AI research, software development, information systems, data privacy, user experience, and technology for real organisations. Seeking opportunities after May 2027 in software engineering, AI product, technology strategy, or information systems, with particular interest in AI systems, databases, internal platforms, and data pipelines.

Education

Indiana University Bloomington Bloomington, IN
B.S. Informatics (Business & Society), Luddy School of Informatics, Computing, and Engineering Expected May 2027

- GPA: 3.50; Hudson & Holland Platinum Scholar (full merit); Direct Admit; first-generation student
- Study abroad: Universidad Complutense de Madrid (UCM), Spring 2026
- Academic focus: artificial intelligence, human-computer interaction, information systems, software development, data, and technology in organisations

Cathedral High School Indianapolis, IN
High School Diploma, High Honours Aug 2019 to May 2023

- GPA: 4.00; AP Scholar; AP Computer Science A; AP Computer Science Principles; Quill and Scroll

Experience

Digital Humans Project Lead Feb 2025 to Present
Laurie Burns McRobbie ServeIT Nonprofit Clinic, Luddy School, Indiana University Bloomington, IN

- Lead applied research into digital humans, AI-driven virtual personas designed to support customer-facing and internal business workflows.
- Investigate how conversational AI and virtual personas could create value across customer interaction, operations, service delivery, and internal organisational processes.
- Evaluate emerging AI applications through a business and human-computer interaction lens, considering user needs, workflow fit, adoption, and responsible implementation.
- Translate exploratory AI research into practical questions around how organisations could use, manage, and integrate digital human systems.

Web Developer Jun 2026 to Jul 2026
National Science Foundation (NSF) Bloomington, IN

- Contributed to a university project examining how consumer applications collect, store, and protect personal data.
- Worked with an industry partner under a non-disclosure agreement (NDA), translating technical findings into appropriate high-level deliverables while protecting confidential information.

User Experience Designer Aug 2025 to Dec 2025
Indiana University Undergraduate Education Bloomington, IN

- Applied user experience methods to research on consumer technology, with emphasis on data collection, storage, privacy, and user understanding.
- Translated technical and privacy considerations into clearer user-facing experiences and communication.

Business Technologist May 2024 to Dec 2024
Public Interest Technology University Network (PIT-UN) Bloomington, IN

- Researched agentic AI and its potential applications in public-interest and nonprofit organisations.
- Studied go-to-market strategy, adoption barriers, and implementation requirements for AI projects intended to continue beyond an initial pilot.

Website Team Lead Jan 2024 to Present
Laurie Burns McRobbie ServeIT Nonprofit Clinic, Luddy School, Indiana University Bloomington, IN

- Lead web development projects for local nonprofit organisations without dedicated in-house engineering support.
- Build and maintain accessible web experiences using React, Python, PostgreSQL, and WCAG 2.1 accessibility practices.
- Translate client requirements into maintainable technical solutions, documentation, and handoffs that partners can continue using after delivery.
- Progressed from first-year student to Website Team Lead while contributing to Serve-AI and other applied technology initiatives.

Restaurant Kid	May 2017 to Jun 2023
Family Chinese Buffet	Greenfield, IN
• Worked across the restaurant floor, till, and kitchen, learning operations from the ground up in a family-run small business. • After COVID-19 closures and staff reductions, rebuilt the family restaurant's website and social media presence from scratch without an outside agency. • Developed an early understanding of how technology, operations, customers, and limited resources interact in a real small-business environment.	

Leadership & Campus Experience

STEM Peer Mentor / MAP Coordinator	Aug 2023 to Present
Faculty and Staff for Student Excellence (FASE), Indiana University Office of Student Life	Bloomington, IN
• Coordinate the Mentor Apprenticeship Programme (MAP), supporting 50+ first-generation and low-income peer mentors through mentor training, Canvas operations, communications, and programme coordination. • Coach first-year STEM students on coding coursework, study habits, campus resources, and practical academic pathways. • Progressed from MAP mentee to mentor and programme coordinator; invited speaker at the IU Leadership Conference 2025.	
Programme Assistant	Aug 2023 to Present
Hudson & Holland Scholars Programme, Indiana University Undergraduate Education	Bloomington, IN
• Support programme operations, events, communications, and student-facing coordination for Hudson & Holland Scholars. • Help connect first-generation, low-income, and rural scholars with academic, research, leadership, and professional opportunities.	

Selected Projects

Digital Humans Research AI, Business Strategy, Human-Computer Interaction	2025 to Present
• Research how AI-driven virtual personas could operate as interfaces between organisations, customers, and internal teams. • Explore the relationship between AI capability, human interaction, business workflows, adoption, and responsible implementation.	
Jade Small Business Technology & Consulting	May 2023 to Present
• Provide web design, branding, technical consulting, and software support for small-business owners. • Started by rebuilding the family restaurant's website and social presence during COVID-19, then expanded the work to community businesses.	
Career Content, Handshake & Instagram Content Strategy	Aug 2023 to Present
• Create practical early-career content covering workplace norms, business-casual dress, professional communication, and career decisions. • Generated 1.2M+ organic views across Handshake and Instagram through student-focused career content.	

Community Experience

Accessibility Analyst	Aug 2026 to Present
Town of Nashville, Indiana, through ServeIT	Bloomington, IN
• Review civic web content through WCAG 2.1 accessibility checks, including navigation and usability considerations for residents. • Document findings and deliver recommendations to the client without making live-site changes.	
Web Designer	Aug 2025 to Dec 2025
Greater Bloomington Chamber of Commerce, through ServeIT	Bloomington, IN
• Designed and maintained Chamber web pages with staff, focusing on navigation, accessibility, and local-business visibility.	
Web Designer	Jan 2025 to May 2025
Indiana Phenology, through ServeIT	Bloomington, IN
• Contributed web design and information architecture work for a nonprofit supporting citizen-science research on seasonal change.	
Web Designer	Aug 2024 to Dec 2024
Middle Way House, through ServeIT	Bloomington, IN

- Led WordPress and Figma redesign work with staff and a student team, improving navigation and accessibility for a crisis-support organisation.

Accessibility Analyst

Jan 2024 to May 2024

City of Bloomington, through ServeIT

Bloomington, IN

- Performed WCAG 2.1 checks using keyboard and screen-reader paths, documenting navigation and usability issues across civic and partner pages.

Web Designer & Instructor

Jan 2018 to Aug 2023

Girls Who Code

Indianapolis, IN

- Taught front-end development and digital literacy to 50+ students and mentored 20+ students through workshops and student-led projects.

Honours & Awards

Luddy Study Abroad Scholarship & HIEP Grant

Jan 2026

Indiana University Bloomington

- Received competitive funding supporting a Spring 2026 semester at Universidad Complutense de Madrid through the Luddy School and Edward L. Hutton International Experiences Program.

Hudson & Holland Platinum Scholar

2023 to Present

Indiana University Bloomington

- Full-merit scholarship recipient and first-generation student in the Luddy School of Informatics, Computing, and Engineering.

Advance College Project (ACP) Dual Credit

May 2023

Indiana University / Cathedral High School

- Completed Indiana University college-level coursework through the Advance College Project while attending Cathedral High School.

Technical Skills

- Programming: Python, TypeScript, JavaScript, SQL, Java, HTML/CSS, LaTeX
- Software: React, Node.js, PostgreSQL, Git, GitHub, REST APIs, WordPress
- AI: Artificial Intelligence, LLMs, RAG, Agentic AI, Digital Humans, Human-Computer Interaction
- Data & Systems: SQL, PostgreSQL, Database Management, ETL, Information Systems, Data Privacy
- Design & Accessibility: Figma, UX Research, User Experience, WCAG 2.1, Accessibility Testing
- Strategy: Business Strategy, Go-to-Market Strategy, Technology Strategy, Technical Communication, Research
- Languages: English, Fuzhounese, Spanish